

Fate's Edge Quickstart

Your first session in 15 minutes

|

Welcome to Fate's Edge

You are exiles, rogues, and survivors in a world where every choice carries weight and every roll of the dice can change the story. This Quickstart contains everything you need to play your first session:

- Reference to the **2-page Cyclopedia** (core rules)
- 4 pre-generated characters
- A complete starter adventure: *The Lantern at Dusk*
- Game Master tips
- Optional simplified magic rules

No other books required.

Core Rules Reference

The complete core rules (dice resolution, Position, Difficulty Values, Story Beats, Boons, combat, etc.) are summarized on the **Fate's Edge Player's Cyclopedia** – a free 2-page reference sheet. **Print it or keep it handy at the table.** This Quickstart assumes you have the Cyclopedia nearby; it focuses on the adventure and pre-generated characters.

1 Pre-Generated Characters

Choose one. All are balanced for the starter adventure.

1. Levi – Soldier

Once a legionary, now a sellsword.

Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 2, Presence 1

Skills: Melee 3, Athletics 2, Endurance 1, Command 1

Talent – Battle Instincts: Once per scene, reroll a failed defense roll.

Asset – Trusted Blade: Your sword never breaks on a Miss.

Bonds: (choose one with another PC) "I saved your life outside Millhaven."

2. Lyra – Scholar

Expelled from the Academy for forbidden research.

Wits 3, Spirit 3, Body 1, Presence 1

Skills: Lore 2, Arcana 2, Investigation 2, Insight 1

Talent – Lorekeeper: Once per session, recall obscure history without rolling.

Asset – Scholar's Satchel: Contains books, reagents, a small telescope.

Bonds: "We both lost our place in Silkstrand."

3. Sera – Shadow

Former guild thief, now a wanderer.

Wits 3, Body 2, Spirit 2, Presence 1

Skills: Stealth 3, Subterfuge 2, Streetwise 1, Melee 1

Talent – Silver Tongue: +1 die to persuade or deceive through speech.

Asset – Shadow's Cloak: +1 die to stealth rolls in dim light.

Bonds: "You kept my secret when the guards came."

4. Mira – Healer

Accused of witchcraft for curing the incurable.

Spirit 3, Wits 2, Body 2, Presence 1

Skills: Medicine 3, Survival 2, Insight 2, Nature 1

Talent – Iron Stomach: Immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food.

Asset – Healer's Kit: Bandages, herbs, basic medical supplies.

Bonds: "You trusted me when no one else would."

Each PC starts with **3 Boons** and **0 Fatigue/Harm**.

2 Starter Adventure – The Lantern at Dusk

Setup

The party is hired by Elder Sarai of the remote village of **Duskwood**. A terrible blight is spreading from the old barrow in the hills – the same barrow

where a cursed lantern was buried centuries ago. The lantern must be brought to a stone circle in the valley to break the curse. But the barrow is not empty.

What the Party Knows

- The lantern is in the central chamber of the barrow.
- The barrow is guarded by restless spirits (the **Duskwrights**).
- A rival treasure hunter, **Quick Lena**, has also entered the barrow.
- The curse will kill the village's crops in three days.

Timers

- **Barrow Collapse [6]** – ticks when the party fails a roll inside (GM advances 1 segment per Miss). At 6, the entrance seals – escape becomes a Desperate group action.
- **Lena's Agenda [4]** – ticks at the end of each scene inside the barrow. When it fills, Lena has already taken the lantern; the party must chase her.

Scene 1 – The Entry

The barrow entrance is a narrow stone passage. A faint green glow pulses from deeper inside. **Obstacle:** A cave-in blocks the way (Body+Athletics to climb, DV 3, Controlled). *Partial:* You get through but disturb rubble – tick Barrow Collapse +1. *Miss:* You are pinned by a rock – mark Harm 1 and tick Collapse +1.

Scene 2 – The Spirit Corridor

The passage widens into a hall where three Duskwrights drift. They do not attack unless provoked, but they will not let anyone pass without an offering. **Offer a memory or a secret** (Presence+Sway, DV 3, Controlled). *Clean Success:* They bow and let you pass. *Partial:* They take your offering but also steal a random piece of equipment (GM chooses). *Miss:* They attack as a single mob (Cap 2, Harm 1 each, 2 Fatigue each on hit). Combat follows normal rules (see Cyclopedia).

Scene 3 – The Lantern Chamber

The lantern sits on a stone altar. Quick Lena is there, trying to pry it loose. **Confront Lena:**

She is not a fighter. Offer a deal or intimidate her (Presence+Sway, DV 3, Controlled). *Success:* She leaves peacefully, but warns that "others will come for it." *Partial:* She agrees to split any reward but demands a favor later (start a Debt Timer [4]). *Miss:* She triggers a trap – a stone door starts closing (tick Collapse +2).

Scene 4 – Escape

After you take the lantern, the barrow begins to collapse in earnest. **Group skill challenge:** The party needs 3 successes before 2 failures to escape. Each PC describes how they help (e.g., Athletics to brace a door, Lore to read ancient escape runes). DV 3, Position Desperate. Each failure ticks Collapse +1. If Collapse reaches 6 before you escape, the entrance seals – you must find another way (start a second Timer [4] to dig out, each success removes 1 segment; on failure, mark Fatigue). *Success:* You burst into the moonlight, lantern in hand. *Failure:* You escape, but someone is left behind – captured or lost. The remaining party must rescue them later.

Resolution

Return the lantern to the stone circle. Breaking the curse requires a simple ritual (Spirit+Lore, DV 2). *Success:* The blight lifts. Elder Sarai rewards each PC with a **String** – "The village owes you." *Partial:* The curse lifts, but the lantern cannot be destroyed – it will attract another danger soon. *Miss:* The curse is only pushed back one year. A dark spirit escapes and will become a recurring enemy.

Advancement

Each PC earns **6–10 XP** at the end. XP can be spent (see Cyclopedia for full costs):

- Raise an Attribute: new rating $\times$ 3 XP (downtime = new rating days)
- Raise a Skill: new level $\times$ 2 XP (downtime = new level days)
- Learn a Minor Talent (2–4 XP) – examples: *Keen Senses*, *Second Wind*, *Combat Reflexes*
- Acquire a Minor Asset (4 XP) – safehouse, contact, or special tool.

Rush rule: Skip downtime by accepting a *Haste timer* [4]. If it fills before you finish, the new ability has a flaw (GM's choice).

3 GM Tips – Running Your First Game

- **Start strong:** Use the cold open – "The barrow's green light flickers. You smell rot. What do you do?"
- **Set DV to 3** by default. Only raise to 4 or 5 if the task is truly legendary.
- **Spend SB early and often.** A single SB can turn a quiet scene into a tense one.
- **Fail forward:** On a Miss, never say "nothing happens." Always introduce a new complication or advance a timer.
- **Use the pre-gens** – they are designed to showcase different play styles.
- **Keep the spotlight moving.** Ask quiet players directly: "Sera, what are you doing while this happens?"
- **End on a cliffhanger.** When the lantern is lifted, describe the ceiling cracking – then say "to be continued."

Optional – Magic in One Page

If a player wants a magical character, use these simplified rules (based on the *Free Caster* path). For full magic systems (Runekeepers, Invokers, Cantors), see the complete *Fate's Edge Player's Guide*.

Spellcasting

Choose a magical **Element** (Fire, Water, Earth, Air, Fate, Life, Luck, Death). Describe your spell using **TAGS**. Each tag increases DV by 1. Dangerous tags (Teleport, Transform, Dominate) increase DV by +2 instead. **DV = 1 + number of tags** (max 6). Roll **Spirit + Arcana**.

Example: "I throw a [Burning] [Area] blast" = DV 3.

Backlash

If you roll a Miss or the GM spends SB, magic backfires:

- 1–2 SB: minor flare, Fatigue 1, eerie sound.
- 3+ SB: Harm 1, the spell affects an ally, or a Patron omen appears.

Sample Spells (DV 2–4)

- *Light* [Illuminate] – DV 2. Create a small, sustained light.

- *HEAL* [HEAL] – DV 2. Heal 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally.
- *Shield of Air* [Ward] [Defend] – DV 3. Gain Position +1 on next defense.
- *Flame Cloak* [Burning] [Area] – DV 3. Enemies suffer –1 die to approach.

License & Credits

Fate's Edge Quickstart © Nicholas A. Gasper. This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License. <http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/> Based on the *Fate's Edge* roleplaying game.

Ready for More?

This Quickstart gives you a complete first session. For the full experience:

- **Player's Guide:** Attributes, Skills, Talents, magic systems, character advancement, and the world.
- **GM Guide:** Timers, fronts, advanced Story Beat management, faction rules, and high-tier play.
- **Adventures:** *Blood and Silk* (village defense), *Beyond Millhaven* (mediation), *The Brass Gate* (heist).

All available under CC-BY from the author. Now gather your dice and step into the Edge.